

Chapter 76-3

Xu Guangyao laughed, the wrinkles at the corners of his eyes particularly prominent. "You weren't this well-behaved when you were calling me old-fashioned in the office."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She retorted, "I didn't call you old-fashioned. I was just discussing the matter at hand."

"I know." Xu Guangyao ran his hand through his hair, revealing a patch of white. He said in a deep voice: "You have talent in this area. Go ahead and do it. It's just that I didn't do well all these years and almost ran Minghui into the ground."

"Did you do your best?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Xu Guangyao was stunned for a moment, then smiled bitterly. "I did my best, but my abilities were limited."

Xu Qingzhu said: "Then that's enough. If you did your best, you have nothing to feel guilty about."

Xu Guangyao stood in the study, silent for a long time.

Xu Qingzhu gazed at his back and noticed that he had aged considerably. He was no longer the tall figure from her memories.

"After I joined the company, you've been under a lot of pressure, haven't you?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Xu Guangyao turned around and smiled. "I was afraid you'd collapse from illness."

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "Don't worry. I'll take good care of myself."

After finishing her conversation with Xu Guangyao in the study, Xu Qingzhu couldn't shake the feeling that something was off.

But she couldn't put her finger on it, though she felt a vague unease in her heart.

After they came out of the study, Sheng Linlang still hadn't emerged from the Buddhist prayer room.

Xu Qingzhu said: "I'll go upstairs to call her."

Over the years, Sheng Linlang hadn't been very social. She only appeared in public view when she occasionally needed to attend banquets. She didn't like shopping either, always staying home alone copying Buddhist scriptures and chanting sutras.

To make it more convenient for her, Xu Guangyao had converted one of the bedrooms in the house into a Buddhist prayer room. Inside was enshrined a Buddha statue that had been invited from a particularly efficacious temple in China¹.

The Buddha statue wasn't large, but it was pure gold.

Although Xu Qingzhu didn't believe in gods or Buddha, she respected Sheng Linlang's religious beliefs.

Besides, this was Sheng Linlang's only hobby.

Xu Qingzhu went upstairs and knocked lightly on the door. Before long, Sheng Linlang opened the door. She was somewhat surprised to see Xu Qingzhu, but smiled and said: "Why did you suddenly come back? You didn't even call."

"I missed you, so I came back." Xu Qingzhu hugged her. "Are you done chanting? It's time to go downstairs for dinner."

Sheng Linlang put the prayer beads she had been fingering onto her fair wrist. "I was just casually chanting. It's nothing formal. I can stop anytime."

"Then let's go eat." Xu Qingzhu held her hand and led her downstairs.

Sheng Linlang's hands were very soft, but her footsteps were unsteady as they went downstairs. Xu Qingzhu glanced at her from the side and noticed that her chin looked thin and gaunt. She couldn't help but frown: "Haven't you been eating properly lately? Why are you so thin?"

Sheng Linlang was startled, then smiled: "I have been eating. It's just that the weather has gotten cold and my appetite isn't good."

"Isn't it usually hot weather that makes people lose their appetite?" Xu Qingzhu said: "It's almost winter. You need to store up some fat for the season."

"It'll get better after a while," Sheng Linlang said dismissively.

Xu Qingzhu felt doubtful in her heart but didn't say anything.

After they finished eating, she called Sheng Linlang to her room, saying she had something to ask.

Xu Qingzhu's room was the same as before she got married. It had always been cleaned by someone, and everything was placed in its original position, untouched by anyone.

Her room was decorated in sky blue tones—a very bright color scheme—completely designed according to her preferences.

Thinking back, it seemed that from childhood to adulthood, whatever she wanted, her parents never denied her.

So she had always lived a very content and happy life.

Sheng Linlang sat on the edge of the bed with her and suddenly asked: "Are you going to stay home and sleep tonight?"

"Would you like me to stay?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Sheng Linlang was taken aback, her expression immediately becoming serious. "Did you have a fight with Liang Shi? What happened?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu denied once again. "Nothing happened between me and Liang Shi. There are just some other things I want to ask you about."

Hearing that nothing was wrong between the two of them, Sheng Linlang finally relaxed.

"What is it then?" Sheng Linlang asked: "Is it related to Jiani? We really haven't been in contact for many years."

"It's not about Yang Jiani," Xu Qingzhu said.

She took a deep breath and was silent for a moment before saying: "What I want to ask about is Su Yao."

"Su Yao?" Sheng Linlang's pupils suddenly contracted. "Why... why are you asking about her?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't hide anything. She smiled bitterly: "I've already met her."

Sheng Linlang's expression became very complicated. Her eyes were also filled with too many emotions—shock, astonishment, sadness, fear... too many things that Xu Qingzhu couldn't understand.

Sheng Linlang opened her mouth several times but couldn't say anything.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu looked at her. "Can you tell me what happened twenty-three years ago?"

Sheng Linlang closed her eyes, tears sliding down her cheeks. She shook her head and said: "How did you find out?"

As she spoke, her hands kept fingering the prayer beads, and the speed kept increasing.

Finally... the string snapped, and the prayer beads scattered all over the floor.

Xu Qingzhu squatted down to pick them up. She bent over and gathered a few, but Sheng Linlang suddenly grabbed her hand. "Don't pick them up. Let the housekeeper clean them up later."

"Are you feeling better?" Xu Qingzhu asked: "If you don't want to talk about it, I won't listen."

"Besides Su Yao, have you met anyone else?" Sheng Linlang asked.

After the initial shock, her emotions were now quite calm. She didn't desperately tell Xu Qingzhu not to meet Su Yao, nor did she storm out, nor did she forcefully insist that Xu Qingzhu not know about these things.

Sheng Linlang only sighed softly, gentle as always.

Like a pool of still water, she could easily soothe the anxiety in one's heart.

Perhaps it was related to her nature. Since childhood, Xu Qingzhu had never seen Sheng Linlang lose her temper. No matter when, she always spoke softly and smiled gently—a typical lady of a prestigious family².

Xu Qingzhu had always felt that those noble young ladies portrayed in TV dramas couldn't compare to even one-thousandth of Sheng Linlang.

Whether in terms of looks or temperament.

That's why she dared to come home and ask, and was certain that Sheng Linlang wouldn't lie to her.

"Also Su Zhe," Xu Qingzhu said gently. "He came to see me yesterday."

"What did he say?" Sheng Linlang asked. "Did he mention what happened before?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "So I wanted to hear what you have to say. What he said may not necessarily be accurate."

Sheng Linlang shook her head with a bitter smile. "It's probably accurate."

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1. 請來的佛 (qǐng lái de fó) - In Chinese Buddhist tradition, Buddha statues are not simply "bought" but "invited" (請) from temples. This reflects the belief that the statue carries spiritual significance and blessing. When a statue comes from a particularly "efficacious" (靈) temple, it's believed to carry stronger spiritual power. ⇐
 2. 大家閨秀 (dà jiā guī xiù) - A traditional Chinese term referring to a young lady from a wealthy, prestigious, or noble family who has been raised with refined manners, education, and grace. Such women were expected to be cultured, modest, elegant, and well-versed in traditional feminine arts. ⇐